

Chicago Tribune



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BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

Several tax hikes take effect Tuesday

In: Higher levies on gas, Zyn and betting. Out: Hotel mini shampoos

By Olivia Olander
Chicago Tribune

People looking to hit the road, bet on sports, book a stay through a short-term rental platform or buy a vape at their corner convenience store in Illinois will have to pay a little more to the state in taxes starting Tuesday.

While Gov. JB Pritzker earlier this year ruled out across-the-board sales tax increases or another attempt to tax higher earners to cope with a tough financial year, several more tightly focused revenue hikes were included in the \$55 billion budget passed by legislators in May and set to take effect July 1.

As part of an annual increase tied to inflation, Illinois' gas tax will increase by about 1 cent to just more than 48 cents per gallon. The tax on diesel fuel will also go up about 1 cent to just under 56 cents per gallon.

For sportsbooks, the state added a per-wager tax of 25 cents for the first 20 million bets placed each year, a levy that goes up to 50 cents for bets beyond that number. The betting tax is expected to bring in about \$36 million.

FanDuel operator Flutter already said last month it would tack on a 50-cent fee for bets placed in Illinois in response.

Users of tobacco and nicotine products will also likely be paying more. Vaping products will be taxed at 45% of wholesale price, up from a rate of 15% set six years ago. Other tobacco products — excluding cigarettes — will also now be subject to the 45% tax, as will nontobacco nicotine products such as Zyn nicotine pouches.

Exactly how those costs will be passed on to consumers remains to be seen. However, it's likely that a \$20 disposable vape could cost close to \$5 more once the 45% wholesale tax goes into effect, and that doesn't factor in the resulting increase in the sales tax at the register, the Tribune previously reported. A can of Zyn pouches that might cost \$4.50 now will likely go up to \$6.50, said Taha Saleem, chief information officer for suburban wholesaler American Distributors.

The tobacco tax increases are expected to raise about \$50 million. Most of that will go to cover Medicaid costs, with \$5 million set aside for tobacco cessa-

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TALIA SPRAGUE/FOR THE TRIBUNE

Weird Al may be the last of his kind

The parody artist's performance at Ravinia Festival brings joy along with a touch of sadness over the notion that there may be no successor to his unique place in pop culture. **Arts & Living**

Dozens killed in cafe, aid lines in Gaza

Israeli forces killed at least 74 people in Gaza on Monday with airstrikes that left 30 dead at a seaside cafe and gunfire that left 23 others dead. **Nation & World**



Chicago Mayor Brandon Johnson, left, talks with senior adviser Jason Lee between meetings with lawmakers in Springfield on April 30. BRIAN CASSELLA/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Johnson's 'pending' lobbyist team draws ethics questions

Three who weren't registered for city reportedly worked during session in Springfield

By Alice Yin, Jeremy Gornor and A.D. Quig
Chicago Tribune

Mayor Brandon Johnson's inner circle worked with outside lobbyists who were not registered to lobby on behalf of the city in the Illinois General Assembly, a practice his office defended after repeated inquiries into the makeup of his intergovernmental affairs team in Springfield.

Email records and Springfield sources indicate that three lobbyists — Lakeisha Purchase, Frank Bass and Vincent Williams —

coordinated with top Johnson officials during the most recent session. But they did not update their state registration to show the city among their lobbying clients before the Illinois General Assembly adjourned June 1.

In an interview Friday, the mayor's new lead Springfield IGA director, John Arena, argued those lobbyists did not need to register because their contracts with the city were still "pending." In the meantime, Purchase was only "helping facilitate" lobbying, while Bass was coordinating with the city's team in his capacity as a

lobbyist for the Chicago Teachers Union and Williams as one for the Chicago Transit Authority, Arena said.

"We couldn't have them declare that they were under contract with the city if the contracts weren't finally approved," Arena said. "So it was kind of a catch-22, but because they were already under contract with a client ... we were going to exchange information that was relevant to those particular fields."

Though Arena maintained that use of these lobbyists without registration was above board,

if state officials were to find the three did not properly disclose their representation of the city's interests, they could be in violation of the law.

The lack of clarity over the extent of the group's work directly for the Johnson administration makes it more challenging to discern whether the lobbyists are following ethics rules, Alisa Kaplan, executive director of government transparency advocate Reform for Illinois and a registered lobby-

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Demonstrators carry cardboard caskets in front of the U.S. Capitol in protest of President Donald Trump's tax breaks and spending cuts package on Monday in Washington. JULIA DEMAREE NIKHINSON/AP

Senate embarks on long day of votes on Trump's big bill

Democrats propose amendments to limit cuts in legislation

By Lisa Mascaro, Kevin Freking and Joey Cappelletti
Associated Press

WASHINGTON — Senators hunkered down Monday to consider proposed amendments to President Donald Trump's big bill of tax breaks and spending cuts amid challenges including the weekend announcement from one GOP senator that he

won't run for reelection after opposing the package over its Medicaid health care cuts.

The grind is expected to take all day, and it could churn into the night. Potential changes were being considered in what's called a vote-a-rama, though most are expected to fail — with Democrats united against the Republican president's legislation and eagerly lined up to challenge it.

"It's time to vote," said Senate Majority Leader John Thune of South Dakota, as the chamber opened. But later he suggested final action could slip.

Senate Democratic Leader

Chuck Schumer of New York said the "hardest choices" for Republicans are still to come. Democrats, he said, are bringing "amendment after amendment after amendment to the floor, so Republicans can defend their billionaire tax cuts and so they can try to explain their massive cuts to Medicaid to people back home."

The day will be pivotal for the Republicans, who have control of Congress and are racing against Trump's July Fourth deadline to wrap up work. The 940-page

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Self-defense claim made in shooting not man's 1st

Suspect in fatal incident in Douglass Park tied to firing on dogs in '23

By Sam Charles and Madeline Buckley
Chicago Tribune

For the second time in three years, Charles Leto has claimed he opened fire in self-defense.

Last week, prosecutors say, he shot at three unarmed teenagers in Douglass Park, killing a 15-year-old boy and seriously wounding a 14-year-old in a crowded park during a summer evening. More than two years earlier, he shot two dogs in Lakeview, killing one and sparking a response by a Chicago police SWAT team, according to an attorney for the Douglass Park victims.

The tragic shooting was decried as "senseless" by a relative of one of the boys, and prosecutors alleged that nothing backs up Leto's claim of self-defense. On the contrary, they said, his account is disputed by witnesses and surveillance video.

Leto, 55, was arrested over the weekend after the shooting early Thursday night near the Douglass Park pool. He was charged with first-degree murder, attempted murder and two other felonies, which Leto, a Chicago Park District lifeguard, claimed to police had been in self-defense after the

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